By maintaining such a large army, the emperor both reduced the number of potential soldiers available to those tempted to oppose him, by taking them into imperial service, and upheld the empire's prestige. Emperors spent much of their time moving around their lands in a vast mobile armed camp which, with military personnel and hangers-on together, may have numbered half a million people. It was the most practical way of demonstrating their wealth and prestige to their subjects and tributaries.

> "WHEN HE TRAVELS THROUGH HIS COUNTRY, THE EMPEROR TAKES FIFTEEN HUNDRED THOUSAND HUMAN BEINGS, HORSEMEN, SOLDIERS, OFFICERS, WOMEN, CHILDREN, WITH TEN THOUSAND ELEPHANTS, AND WITH A GREAT DEAL OF ARTILLERY."
>
> FRENCH TRAVELLER **AUGUSTIN HIRIART**, C.1605

CAVALRY AND INFANTRY

As a fighting force, the Mughal army was centred upon the use of cavalry. The sheer number of horsemen was astonishing, at times almost certainly exceeding 100,000 men. The need to find mounts for cavalry on this scale – especially when every man would at least aspire to owning two horses – made horse-breeding a major activity in parts of India, notably the Punjab and Sind, but warhorses also had to be imported in bulk from Central Asia via Kabul. The majority of the cavalry were lightly equipped mounted archers, although there were also large numbers of heavy cavalry who wore substantial body armour – typically a helmet, plate cuirass, and coat of mail – and who had the sword as their main weapon. The horsemen were expected to win battles; but little was expected of the armed peasants who made up the infantry. They were men of low status conscripted into part-time military service, and made up the numbers at little cost to their employers, living off a meagre diet of flour, rice, butter, and salt. Infantry might carry any of a variety of edged weapons, but their major arm was the matchlock musket.

Steel weapons
Many of the warriors depicted in the battle below are brandishing the type of distinctive curved sword, *talwar*, that was common in Mughal India.



GUNPOWDER WEAPONS

Although the Mughals cannot be credited with introducing gunpowder weapons into the Indian subcontinent – Francisco de Almeida defeated combined Arabian and Egyptian forces at the Battle of Diu, in February 1509, with ships' cannon – the first use of cannon and firearms there certainly dates from around the start of the Mughal period. Artillery and arquebuses played a crucial part in Babur's victory at Panipat in 1526. In that early period the Mughals depended heavily on foreign expertise in this area. The Ottoman Turks and various Europeans, especially Portuguese from Goa, carried out the transfer of technology, demonstrating how to found cannon and make firearms and gunpowder. Indian craftsmen were quick learners. By the end of the 16th century their matchlock muskets were better made than most European firearms and they were manufacturing light and heavy cannon of brass and bronze. Foreign experts were still employed to help with the aiming and firing of artillery pieces. When the Mughal army was on campaign, its heavy artillery was drawn

Ceremonial dagger
This extremely ornate 17th-century dagger with scabbard is typical of those from the Mughal period. Its ram-shaped hilt is studded with semi-precious stones. It would have been used for ceremonial purposes.